

A CLOSER LOOK

The first 12 weeks

We talk about babies being fully formed at birth, but of course there are still myriad phases of growth for them to go through, physically, mentally, and emotionally. When you look back in three months at photographs of your baby on the day he was born, you'll barely be able to believe how that tiny, wrinkled, curled-up bundle could become the bouncing, smiling, laughing, grasping, and inquisitive little person you hold now.

1 WEEK OLD Your baby will spend time curled up as he adjusts to life outside the uterus. His fists will remain clenched for much of the time.

What you can do: Get your baby to look in a mirror—he loves looking at faces and will seek out yours immediately after birth.

2 WEEKS OLD Your baby may now be able to hold his head up for a few seconds when held to your shoulder.

What you can do: Make faces at your baby and stick out your tongue. He will try to mimic you.

3 WEEKS OLD You may notice that your baby's movements are less jerky and more controlled. He is gaining control of his muscles. Some of his more primitive reflexes are beginning to fade.

What you can do: Although your days and nights are still a blur, you can help your baby to start to differentiate them by darkening his room at night to help him identify nighttime.



4 WEEKS OLD At four weeks, your baby's neck muscles are growing stronger and you may notice him holding his head up a little longer when he is supported on you.

What you can do: Place your baby on his tummy; he will try to lift his head up from the surface. This helps him build more strength in his back and neck.

5 WEEKS OLD Your baby can now focus both eyes and is working his eye muscles hard to focus on objects near and far. He can track a moving object from the side of his vision until it is in front of him.

What you can do: Young babies love black-and-white patterns. Try placing some where your baby can look at them while he is lying down.

6 WEEKS OLD At around six weeks you will see something that makes all the hard work worthwhile: your baby's first smile. He is becoming more socially aware and responds to your voice, holding your gaze when you speak.

What you can do: Talk to your baby, it will help him develop his language skills even though he can't respond with words. You may even get a few throaty noises in reply.

FASCINATING FACTS

8–10 in

(20–25 cm) is the distance your baby can focus on at two weeks old.

4 weeks

At four weeks your baby will be less curled up than after birth.

10 days

The umbilical cord usually comes off naturally 10 days after birth.